GRADE 11 / History / English

Explain the Russian revolutions

01 Understand

Learning goals: Sequence the two revolutions of 1917 • Connect war and domestic pressures • Distinguish an event from an interpretation

Russia’s involvement in the First World War intensified military, economic and political pressures. Food shortages and discontent weakened confidence in tsarist rule.

The February Revolution led to the abdication of Nicholas II. The Provisional Government faced continuing war and competing political authority.

In the October Revolution the Bolsheviks took power. Explaining this outcome requires attention to government weaknesses, political organisation and popular demands.

Conventional names use the old Russian calendar

Stage	Key change	Question to ask
February 1917	Tsar abdicates	why did support collapse?
Between revolutions	Provisional Government	why did problems persist?
October 1917	Bolsheviks take power	how did they gain support and act?

02 Follow the reasoning

Explain why ending tsarist rule did not immediately resolve Russia’s crisis.

1. The February Revolution changed political leadership but inherited war and shortages.

2. Continuing involvement in the war sustained hardship and discontent.

3. Rival centres of authority and competing programmes made effective government difficult; political change alone did not remove the underlying pressures.

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Practise with purpose

03 Try before checking

Use paper or your notebook. Show your reasoning. For written responses, use evidence and explain your choices. Suggested time: 15–20 minutes.

1. Identify the ruler who abdicated in 1917.

2. Why should a historian compare a Bolshevik slogan with other evidence?

3. Give one reason not to merge February and October into a single event.

04 Check and correct

1. Nicholas II.

2. A slogan reveals political aims and persuasion, but not by itself actual support or implementation.

3. They removed different authorities and occurred in different political circumstances.

Common mistake to avoid

The conventional February and October names refer to the Julian calendar then used in Russia; dates differ in the Gregorian calendar.

Reflect and revisit

Identify one correction in your own words. Attempt a similar question tomorrow without looking at the guide. If you are still unsure, take your attempt to a teacher or tutor.

Coverage and sources

CAPS topic focus: Communism in Russia, 1900–1940: revolutions of 1917

DBE CAPS, Grades 10–12: History. Section 3 content and skills. This is a focused supplement, not a complete syllabus or prescribed literature replacement.

Open the official DBE curriculum reference

Content and visuals: original SmartBridge FET. AI-assisted authoring; subject-teacher and language-specialist review pending. Report an issue with the pack ID hist-11.